WELLS FARGO ADVISORS

A report from the Investment Strategy Committee – April 2012

Cyclical Asset Allocation Quarterly

Our cyclical asset allocation process is based on a rolling three-year outlook – which means that the Investment Strategy Committee evaluates how the portfolios are expected to perform over the next 36 months based on asset valuations as well as economic and market outlooks. This is different than a tactical or momentum-driven allocation process, which constantly adjusts to changing short-term conditions. The cyclical approach is very much driven by fundamental valuations, which can lead to entering and exiting positions as opportunities arise. Over time, this approach may avoid chasing unsustainable, wild market swings driven by fear and greed near the end of cyclical declines or advances.

Overview

- **The U.S. economy continues to recover at a relatively slow pace.** We believe our modest growth/modest inflation outlook will be valid over the course of the next year or two. Economic growth in 2012 is likely to be in the 2.2% area. As we have mentioned in the past, the growth rate experienced during this recovery continues to be weaker than most. Our Macro Strategy team recently reduced the probability of the U.S. slipping back into recession to 20% from the previous 35% level.
- **Although the price of oil has been on the rise, slower global growth is likely to reduce inflationary pressures.** China and Brazil have both recently lowered their economic growth estimates. Europe and Japan appear poised to contribute little if anything to global growth this year. High unemployment continues to translate into minimal wage gains in the United States, which should also help keep a lid on inflation. We expect the Consumer Price Index (CPI) to increase 2.5% this year, a modest rise when looked at historically.
- **Consumer confidence and small business optimism have rebounded somewhat but are still hovering at levels seen 12 months ago.** Both remain below levels normally associated with a healthy economic environment.
- **Businesses remain hesitant to boost inventories.** The inventory to sales ratio remains relatively low as many businesses remain cautious on the recovery and are worried the economy may falter. Inventory rebuilding is adding to economic growth as seen in the fourth quarter of last year.
- **Over the last year, the unemployment rate has come down from 9% to the current 8.3% level but remains high by historical standards.** Slow improvement in the labor market should continue in coming quarters. We look for the unemployment rate to be hovering in the 8% area at the end of this year. The slow pace of labor market improvement is one of the key reasons why the Federal Reserve recently stated that it is unlikely to raise interest rates until late 2014 at the earliest.
- **Low mortgage interest rates have helped the housing market whittle down excess inventories to some extent, but prices in many parts of the country are still falling based on recent data from the National Association of Realtors.** Housing has not provided the usual boost to economic growth in this recovery but may be at or near a bottom.
- **As we move through the middle portion of this global economic recovery, we continue to take a more balanced approach in the equity portion of the portfolios.** While we are keeping a slight cyclical bias, earnings growth is likely to slow substantially in this year versus 2011. Earnings growth in the quarters ahead should still be led by those sectors more sensitive to the ebb and flow of the global economy.
- **On the international front, we continue to be cautious in the near-term due to continuing political risks in Europe and a slowdown in the emerging world.** However, many countries in the emerging world have the flexibility to lower interest rates to help stimulate their economies. Global issues such as the turmoil surrounding the euro zone debt crisis and Middle East tensions represent the greatest risks to the U.S. economy, in our opinion.
- **We expect interest rates to gradually rise over the next several years.** High-yield valuations are attractive, in our opinion, and the high-yield sector appears poised to outperform in a gradually rising rate environment and in an economy that continues to grow modestly.

IMPORTANT NOTE: All of our allocation recommendations assume there is no application of leverage (borrowing funds to create larger positions). Leverage changes the return/risk profile of investment products, and its use is inconsistent with the fundamentals underlying these recommendations.

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In our opinion ...

Over the course of the last six months, the U.S. economy has been making noticeable positive progress. The economy is moving ahead at a better pace than early last year but is still growing below the long-term trend of approximately 3%. The overall growth recorded in this recovery continues to be slower than most over the last 50 years. Our analysis suggests gross domestic product (GDP) growth in 2012 will be in the 2.2% area.

The bulk of the global growth has been coming from emerging countries in Asia, South America and elsewhere over the last few years, but these regions are experiencing economic slowdowns. Inflationary pressures in the emerging countries have eased to some extent, and with slower economic growth, some developing nations have started to ease monetary policy in an attempt to stimulate their economies. In fact, recent moves by China to reduce the amount of reserves held by banks could mark only the beginning of a period of easing in the emerging world as slower growth in the industrialized nations reduce global demand.

Many emerging economies are growing faster than the U.S. economy. During the economic downturn following the financial crisis, most of the emerging countries did not experience the same magnitude of economic slowdown. Despite the recent restructuring of Greek debt, sovereign debt fears are not likely to go away soon and many European countries have implemented more stringent government austerity measures. The potential for a debt crisis contagion has eased to some extent, at least in the short-term, but problems remain. We will be paying close attention to developments in some of the larger economies in the euro zone, including Italy and Spain, in coming months. Countries such as Australia and China that had earlier initiated a series of interest rate hikes in an effort to head off inflationary pressures are now looking at ways to ease monetary policy as the global economy slows. These developments will be important factors in determining the sustainability of the global recovery in the coming year.

Many investors perceive the markets as more susceptible to event risk than in the past. While it may seem we are experiencing a heightened state of risk given the recent headlines surrounding the euro zone sovereign debt crisis or the seemingly growing potential for a conflict with Iran, some level of uncertainty plagues the financial markets most of the time. Risks associated with unexpected negative events such as last year's devastating earthquake in Japan will always be something investors will potentially be forced to deal with on a moment's notice. We continue to believe that diversification across a number of asset classes is one of the best ways to help a portfolio fight against unforeseen events.

Our outlook for a modest growth/modest inflation environment is still intact. Economic growth in the United States, in our opinion, will accelerate from last year's slow pace. Domestically, inflationary periods in the past have usually been associated with strong economic growth, low unemployment, rising wages and strong demand for credit. None of these characteristics are present in the current economic environment. Even though the global economy has slowed, we are projecting a continuation of the recovery that has been in place for more than two years.

The labor market has been slow to recover in this cycle. Unemployment remains well above the longer-term average, and many have been out of work for an extended period. In fact, the government recently reported that the average duration of unemployment is still very close to the recent record high of nearly 41 weeks. By any measure, the ranks of the long-term unemployed are at very high levels. The skills required in today's labor market have changed, and many of the types of jobs created during the last 10 to 15 years are unlikely to require as many workers in the future. Unfortunately, more than 40% of those who are currently unemployed have been out of work for six months or longer. More than 8 million jobs were lost in the last recession. Clearly, it will take time to regain those jobs when the economy is growing slowly. We believe the labor market will continue to slowly improve and project that the unemployment rate will be hovering in the 8% area at year-end versus the long-term average of approximately 5.6%. In a recent survey of small business owners, the top concerns cited were the uncertainty surrounding the cost of hiring a a new employee, the regulatory environment they will be operating in and what their tax rates will be over the next five or more years. A stable operating climate would allow businesses to make longer-term decisions concerning future investment and expansion. Most businesses make strategic decisions based on time frames looking out far longer than one or two years.

In the middle portion of most economic cycles, earnings growth typically slows from the pace seen earlier in the recovery. Our expectation is for the stock market to have a relatively modest upside in 2012. We believe the global economic recovery will continue to move ahead over the next 12 months. Of course, there are headwinds that could affect the pace of growth. Europe remains a question mark, and the Chinese and Brazilian economies have slowed in recent months. In addition, investors are wondering if the Federal Reserve will embark on another round of quantitative easing over the course of the next few quarters. If the economy falters and unemployment remains at elevated levels, we believe the Fed would likely announce another round of asset purchases (i.e., quantitative easing) that would inject more liquidity into the system, keep longer-term interest rates low, and encourage borrowing and lending. We do not think the Fed will sit on its hands and do nothing with economic growth sluggish and the unemployment rate not showing steady improvement. The Fed has already told investors the fed funds rate will likely remain near zero until late 2014 at least. The U.S. central bank does not want to make the mistake of raising interest rates and reducing liquidity too soon. The investing public believes there is a high degree of uncertainty over the sustainability of the expansion. However, keep in mind that corporate profits continue to increase and operating margins are above their historic average.

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Economic and market considerations

Based on current economic policy and market conditions, the Investment Strategy Committee has used the following themes in its asset allocation decisions.

Debt markets

The Fed has extended the time frame for interest rates to likely stay low or near zero until at least late 2014. The benchmark federal funds target rate (the interest rate at which banks lend to other member banks) currently stands at 0% to 0.25%. With the global turmoil emanating from Europe, the Middle East and elsewhere, investors have flocked to U.S. Treasuries for their perceived lower risk in an uncertain world. As a result, even with the recent rise in yields on Treasury securities, interest rates remain historically low. We suspect that interest rates will slowly rise over the coming year or two, but few other conservative options exist for investors. We expect the yield on the 10-year Treasury to be in the 3% area by the end of this year compared to the recent 2.25% level.

With yields so low, some investors are tempted to extend their time horizons in search of higher income. Many people feel that savers and retirees are being punished by low interest rates. We think investors should remain disciplined in the current environment. Over the next few years, we believe significant risks are present in the fixed income markets, especially in longer-dated instruments. Note that although we modestly reduced the amount allocated to short-term fixed income in all of the income models, we continue to hold significant exposure to that asset class in each of the models. These same income models do not allocate any funds to long-term fixed income. In our opinion, it is more desirable to hold allocations in high-yield fixed income than move out further on the maturity timeline. Still, our high-yield allocations fell in those models containing a fixed income component. The remaining high-yield allocations boost the yields of the portfolios and help maintain an element of cyclicality.

In the most recent Federal Open Market Committee post-meeting press release (dated March 13, 2012), the committee decided "to continue its program to extend the average maturity of its holdings of securities." This program, announced last September and dubbed "Operation Twist" by market participants, was done with the goal of lowering long-term interest rates. We would not be surprised to see additional measures taken by the Fed in coming quarters if the economy stumbles. The Fed hopes lower interest rates will encourage borrowing by businesses and consumers. So far, the results have been difficult to quantify, but rates are still historically low.

Fixed income remains an important asset class in portfolios despite the low interest rate environment. Allocations to fixed income can help diversify an investor's overall portfolio. Even within the fixed income segment, investors should diversify their holdings. We currently recommend an overweight position in client portfolios in both investment-grade corporate bonds and preferred securities. We also currently recommend a slight overweight in the municipal segment of the fixed income market. In addition, we currently recommend an underweight in Treasury securities and Treasury Inflation-Protected Securities (TIPS). Finally, we currently recommend a slight underweight position in agency securities.

Investing in fixed income securities involves certain risks, such as market risk, if sold prior to maturity, and credit risk, especially if investing in high-yield bonds, which have lower ratings and are subject to greater volatility. Bond prices fluctuate inversely to changes in interest rates. Therefore, a general rise in interest rates can result in the decline of the value of your investment.

Although Treasuries are considered free from credit risk, they are subject to other types of risks. These risks include interest-rate risk, which may cause the underlying value of the bond to fluctuate.

TIPS have special tax consequences generating "phantom income" on the "inflation compensation" component of principal. A holder of TIPS may be required to report this income annually although no income related to inflation compensation is received until maturity.

Equities

The U.S. economy is expected to grow only around 2.2% in 2012. Based on this belief and where we currently are in the economic cycle, our analysis suggests earnings growth will be substantially slower in 2012 when compared to the last couple of years. We see S&P 500 operating earnings rising approximately 5% this year versus an 18% increase in 2011. We project that the S&P 500 will finish 2012 in the 1,325-1,375 range. As often occurs at this point in the cycle, the equity markets have experienced a period of very volatile range trading over most of the last 15 months as investors digested the gains in the major indices from the March 2009 recession lows. In addition, uncertainties surrounding the sustainability of the economic recovery and the magnitude of the slowdown in earnings growth contributed to market volatility last year. Despite recent positive progress, the euro zone debt crisis has heightened investor anxiety, and events in the Middle East are still quite unsettling. Because of these concerns, as we work through the middle portion of this economic cycle, we have taken a more balanced approach toward portfolio allocations. We are recommending that clients continue to carry only a slight cyclical bias in terms of sector weightings. Over the next 12 months or so, we anticipate looking for opportunities to increase exposure to those equity sectors most sensitive to the ebb and flow of the global economy.

Our model changes in this rebalancing are intended to reflect an increased appetite for risk. In general, we have moved funds from fixed income to the equity asset classes. We continue to carry reduced exposures to emerging-market equity in all of the models. We believe it is appropriate to carry meaningful small- and mid-cap allocations in the Moderate Growth and Long-Term Growth models. Smaller- and mid-cap equities have historically been market underperformers in times of uncertainty and tepid growth, but we feel the American economy is moving ahead at a reasonable pace. We have reintroduced real estate exposure to a number of the models based on our belief that the downside from here is limited and improvement will be seen over the next three years. Stocks overall, in our opinion, appear to be trading at more attractive valuations versus bonds. Thus, our weightings have moved more toward equities in the portfolios.

Nearly all of our current concerns are on the international front. While we continue to believe the rebalancing in emerging-market

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economies away from exports and toward domestic consumption will be a major theme in coming years, sluggish growth in the developed countries is likely to have a meaningful impact on emerging-country growth. Monetary policy in some emerging countries will likely be loosened further in the quarters ahead in response to slower growth in the developed world as well as slowdowns in their domestic economies. However, longer term, inflation will likely become an issue at some point. The global expansion has moderated but does not appear to be heading toward recession.

The prices of small- and mid-cap company stocks are generally more volatile than large-company stocks. They often involve higher risks because smaller companies may lack the management expertise, financial resources, product diversification and competitive strengths to endure adverse economic conditions.

Style

The slower growth environment that we see ahead requires, in our opinion, an allocation slightly more weighted toward growth versus value. In volatile times such as the present, investors often choose growth as a more dependable style versus the more economically sensitive value side of the coin. We continue to carry a 55%/45% growth versus value weighting across large-, mid- and small-cap equity classes. While cyclical earnings growth has been a major driver of earnings and earnings expectations in this recovery, growth indices have outperformed value across all market caps over the last 12 months. One reason is that financial stocks make up a good portion of most value indices. The Financial sector as a whole has underperformed the S&P 500 by a substantial margin over the last year. We remain underweight the Financial sector in our large-cap portfolio allocations.

The models

We have five cyclical asset allocation models. For investors with income as a primary objective, our allocations attempt to limit market risk and price volatility, as income investors tend to favor preservation of principal. However, maintaining purchasing power over a long period of time is also an important investment objective, and we also include what are perceived as more risk-oriented assets, even in our income portfolios, toward that goal. For those investors with growth objectives, our allocations are weighted more toward stocks, which usually have a fair amount of volatility and risk. Across all models, we stress diversification.

We pay attention to Wells Fargo Advisors' longer-term strategic Capital Market Assumptions (CMAs) when allocating among the various asset classes. Our goal is to make cyclical adjustments around the long-term CMAs based on where we are in the economic cycle. While there are economic uncertainties on the near-term horizon, we have increased risk across all of the portfolios. We also continue to have some aversion to longer maturity fixed income vehicles. (For more information abou the CMAs, ask your Financial Advisor for a complimentary copy of our report, "2011 Strategic Allocations and Capital Market Assumptions.")

In terms of overall allocations to the various asset classes, we made a number of adjustments to the models this quarter. Global uncertainties have lifted to some extent and, as a result, we have increased our allocations to equities in most of the portfolios versus the prior quarter. In the models containing a fixed income component, we continued to hold a significant allocation in short-term fixed income. In addition, some of the sector allocations within the large-cap equity asset class were altered to reflect the underlying market movement that has occurred in recent months. These equity sector adjustments continue to reflect a more balanced stance as we pass through the middle portion of this cycle.

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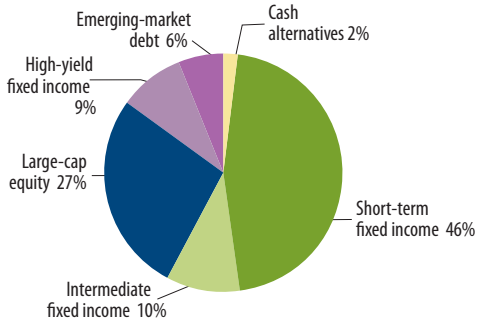
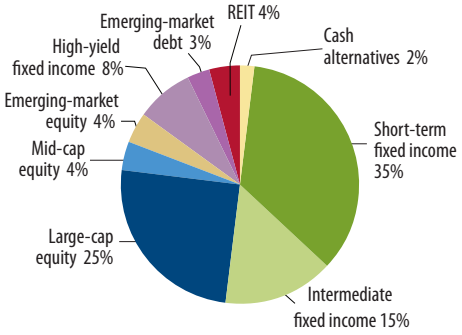
Moderate Income



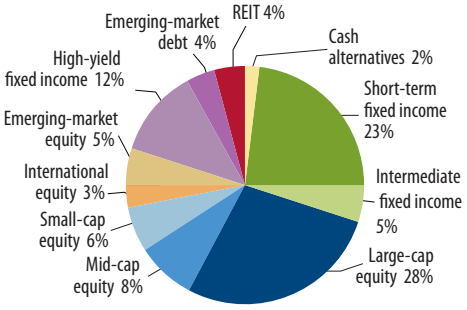
For the Moderate Income model, as with most of the other portfolios, our allocations have moved more toward equities versus the benchmark. In terms of fixed income, we do not want to be too far out on the yield curve. More than half of the portfolio is allocated between short-term fixed income (down to 46% from the previous 50%) and intermediate fixed income (remains 10%). We prefer a shorter duration in the fixed income portion of this portfolio and have not allocated any funds to long-term fixed income. High-yield fixed-income exposure was decreased to 9% from the previous 13% and will still maintain some cyclical sensitivity. These funds were moved to emerging-market debt (increased to 6%) and large-cap equity (now 27% versus the previous 25%). Given our cautionary stance concerning the international equity markets, we would rather take our risk in the domestic markets in this portfolio. This portfolio does not carry exposure to real estate or small- or mid-cap equities at this point. The portfolio allocation is now 71% fixed income, 27% equities and 2% cash (previously 73% fixed income, 25% equities and 2% cash).

Conservative Growth & Income



For the Conservative Growth and Income model, several adjustments were made. Our large-cap equity allocation still stands at 25%. Our exposure to emerging-market equity continues to be 4%. We have reestablished our allocation to emerging-market debt with a 3% position (0% previously). This allocation was funded by eliminating our exposure to international equity (previously 3%). We have reduced our exposure to short-term fixed income by 6% (now 35%) and reduced our allocation to high-yield fixed income by 2% (now 8%). These funds were used to fund a 4% allocation to real estate (previously 0%) and a 4% allocation to mid-cap equity (previously 0%). As in the other income models, we still hold a substantial allocation to short-term fixed income. In this model we do not hold any position in small-cap equity. The allocation to intermediate-term fixed income remains 15%. We do not carry a long-term fixed- income position in this portfolio. The portfolio allocation is now 61% fixed income, 37% equities and 2% cash (previously 66% fixed income, 32% equities and 2% cash).

Moderate Growth & Income



Asset allocation cannot eliminate the risk of fluctuating prices and uncertain returns.

The Moderate Growth and Income model has been adjusted in a number of areas. As in the Conservative Growth and Income model, we decreased our allocation to short-term fixed income (to 23% from 29%). Our mid-cap equity exposure held steady at 8%. We initiated a small-cap position of 6%. The large-cap equity allocation has been decreased 3% (now 28%). As in most of the other models, we removed funds from the international equity asset class (now 3% versus the previous 5%) as we are cautious concerning overseas equity markets. We remain underweight non-U.S. equities versus the benchmark in this model. We initiated a 4% real estate position in this portfolio. Our emerging-market equity exposure remains unchanged at 5%. As for fixed income, our exposure to high-yield fixed income in this portfolio was reduced by 3% (previously 15%). Our allocation to intermediate-term fixed income is unchanged (5%). We increased our emerging-market debt exposure to 4% (previously 0%). Like the other models, this portfolio does not carry an allocation to long-term fixed income. The portfolio allocation is now 54% equities, 44% fixed income and 2% cash (previously 49% equities, 49% fixed income and 2% cash).

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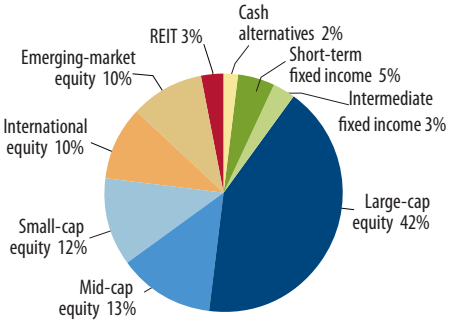
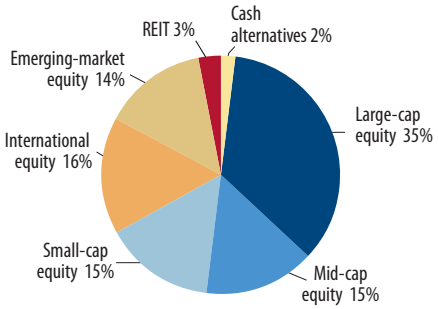
Moderate Growth



In the Moderate Growth model, we increased the allocation to large-cap equities by 4% (now 42%) at the expense of high-yield fixed income (now 0% from the previous 5%). In addition, as in other models, we initiated a position in real estate (now 3%). Our mid-cap equity (13%) and small-cap equity (12%) positions remain unchanged. The allocation to international equity was decreased by 2% (now 10%). Emerging market equity exposure remains 10%. Traditionally, the Moderate Growth portfolio is heavily weighted toward stocks. In terms of fixed income allocations, we maintained a 5% allocation to short-term fixed income and a 3% allocation to intermediate-term fixed income. There is no exposure to long-term fixed income in this portfolio. There is also no exposure to emerging-market debt. The portfolio is now 90% equities, 8% fixed income and 2% cash (previously 85% equities, 13% fixed income and 2% cash).

Long-Term Growth



Asset allocation cannot eliminate the risk of fluctuating prices and uncertain returns.

The Long-Term Growth portfolio is an all-equity strategy focused primarily on growth with little regard to cash flow. Therefore, there is no exposure to fixed income in this model. Large-cap equity exposure was decreased by 5% (now 35%) to fund increased allocations to small-cap and mid-cap equities. The small-cap allocation is now 15% (previously 13%) while mid-cap exposure is 15% (previously 13%). As in the other models, a real estate position was established (now 3%). International equity was decreased by 2% (now 16%). Emerging-market equity exposure held steady at 14%, and there is no exposure to emerging-markets debt. The portfolio's overall allocation remains unchanged at 98% equities and 2% cash.

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Cyclical Asset Allocation models *(Second quarter 2012)*

For more information on the Cyclical Asset Allocation Portfolio (CAAP) program, please ask your Financial Advisor.

	Moderate Income		Conservative Growth & Income		Moderate Growth & Income		Moderate Growth		Long-Term Growth	
	Current	Change	Current	Change	Current	Change	Current	Change	Current	Change
Cash alternatives	2%	none	2%	none	2%	none	2%	none	2%	none
Short-term fixed income	46%	(4%)	35%	(6%)	23%	(6%)	5%	none		
Intermediate fixed income	10%	none	15%	none	5%	none	3%	none		
Long-term fixed income										
High-yield fixed income	9%	(4%)	8%	(2%)	12%	(3%)	0%	(5%)		
REIT equity			4%	4%	4%	4%	3%	3%	3%	3%
Large-cap equity	27%	2%	25%	none	28%	(3%)	42%	4%	35%	(5%)
Mid-cap equity			4%	4%	8%	none	13%	none	15%	2%
Small-cap equity					6%	6%	12%	none	15%	2%
International equity			0%	(3%)	3%	(2%)	10%	(2%)	16%	(2%)
Emerging-market equity			4%	none	5%	none	10%	none	14%	none
Emerging-market debt	6%	6%	3%	3%	4%	4%				
Total	100%		100%		100%		100%		100%	

Asset allocation cannot eliminate the risk of fluctuating prices and uncertain returns.

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Cyclical Asset Allocation models

Cyclical Asset Allocation models provide a rolling three-year outlook and are based not only on past performance of various asset classes but, more importantly, on future expectations. The Investment Strategy Committee focuses on yield for income accounts, return for growth accounts and risk exposure for all accounts by using quantitative research and qualitative experience.

Because the committee continually looks forward, the recommended allocations may change in periods of less than three years if market conditions warrant a change. The charts in this report illustrate the various allocations based on investor type. Changes to the models may be made quarterly.

Analyst certification: The strategist who prepared the report hereby certifies that the views expressed in this report accurately reflect his personal views about the subject companies and their securities. The strategist also certifies that he has not been, is not, and will not be receiving direct or indirect compensation for expressing the specific recommendation(s) or view(s) in this report.

Scott Wren, Senior Equity Strategist

Important disclaimers

Past performance is no guarantee of future results.

An index is not managed and is unavailable for direct investment.

Asset allocation and diversification do not guarantee a profit or protect against loss.

Investing in foreign securities presents certain risks not associated with domestic investments, such as currency fluctuation, political and economic instability, and different accounting standards. This may result in greater share price volatility. These risks are heightened in emerging markets.

The prices of small- and mid-cap company stocks are generally more volatile than large-company stocks. They often involve higher risks because smaller companies may lack the management expertise, financial resources, product diversification and competitive strengths to endure adverse economic conditions.

Investing in fixed income securities involves certain risks, such as market risk if sold prior to maturity and credit risk especially if investing in high-yield bonds, which have lower ratings and are subject to greater volatility. All fixed income investments may be worth less than original cost upon redemption or maturity.

There are special risks associated with an investment in real estate, including credit risk, interest rate fluctuations and the impact of varied economic conditions. Distributions from REIT investments are taxed at the owner's tax bracket.

The Cyclical Asset Allocation program is not designed for excessively traded or inactive accounts and may not be suitable for all investors. Please carefully review the Wells Fargo Advisors advisory disclosure document for a full description of our services. The minimum account size for this program is $50,000.

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Certain investments may be mentioned that are not readily realizable. This means that it may be difficult to sell or realize the investment or obtain reliable information regarding its value. The levels and basis of taxation can change.

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